

INDUSTRY PERSPECTIVE AND PRACTICAL GUIDE

The Airport Infrastructure Delivery Gap

A practical guide to keeping funding, procurement and approval decisions connected.

For airport professionals and their delivery partners.

01 / EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Keep the basis of each decision with the project.

One manageable delivery risk: losing the context that the next reviewer needs.

Airport projects depend on more than funding and a schedule. Teams also need to carry the basis of each decision across planning, funding, approvals, procurement and closeout.

This guide offers a practical way to make that record usable: connect the relevant facts, sources, assumptions, decisions and next owner. It addresses one manageable delivery risk, not every cause of delay. ACRP Report 21 already establishes the value of documenting project-delivery decisions; this guide extends that discipline across the broader project record. [6]

START WITH THIS QUESTION

Could a new project lead explain the chosen path without asking the colleague who made the decision?

Use this at your next review

Choose one live project. Identify its next consequential decision. Check the source, unresolved assumption and responsible owner before committing further.

The result should be a record another airport professional can inspect, challenge and maintain.

Choose your starting point

Capital and cost context	03–04 →
Worked airport project	08 →
Decision-record template	09 →
Team diagnostic	11 →
Eleven practical habits	12 →
Practical close	14 →

Audience: airport leadership, finance, procurement, grants, planning, engineering and delivery partners. This is practical guidance, not original sector-wide research or a compliance determination.

02 / CAPITAL AGENDA

A large agenda. Two different measures.

Both estimates cover 2025–2029. Neither is money available to spend.

ACI-NA / INDUSTRY ESTIMATE [1]

\$173.9B

Estimated airport infrastructure needs across the study's scope.

FAA / NPIAS DEVELOPMENT [2]

\$67.5B

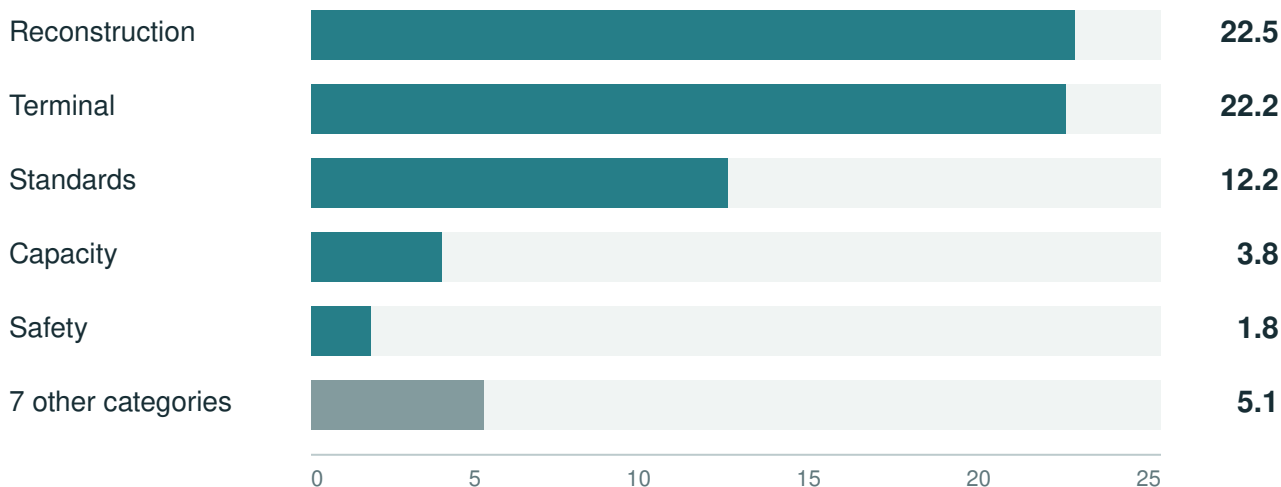
Eligible and justified development identified in the national plan.

DO NOT SUBTRACT THESE TOTALS

Their scope and inclusion criteria differ. The difference is not a measured funding shortfall, and neither figure represents committed funding.

Where NPIAS development is concentrated

USD BILLIONS / 2025–2029



Reconstruction and terminal represent approximately **66%** of the exact \$67.599B table total. The remaining \$5.088B comprises Access, Other, Noise, ATC Tower, Environmental, New Airport and Security—not a residual category.

[1] ACI-NA 2025–2029 study, p. 9. [2] FAA NPIAS 2025–2029, Table 4; narrative updated July 22, 2026. The FAA page still lists this as the current NPIAS. See linked sources on p. 15.

03 / COST EXPOSURE

Time can change the cost of unchanged scope.

Separate historical context from a planning scenario.

INCREASE SINCE 2014, AS REPORTED BY ACI-NA IN 2025 [1]

38.3%

Construction costs

31.7%

General inflation

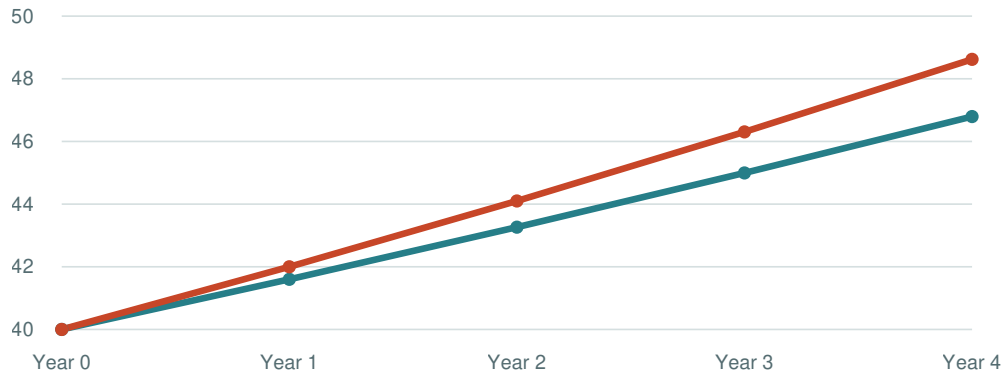
6.6 pp

Difference in increases

An illustrative \$40 million project

Unchanged scope; constant assumed annual escalation; annual compounding. These are selected scenarios, not a forecast or an estimate of avoidable delay.

PROJECT COST / USD MILLIONS · VERTICAL AXIS STARTS AT \$40M



4% annual assumption

Year 4: **\$46.8M**

Increase: approximately **\$6.8M**

5% annual assumption

Year 4: **\$48.6M**

Increase: approximately **\$8.6M**

Record the estimate date and escalation assumptions alongside the budget. Revisit them when scope, market conditions or the delivery window changes.

[1] ACI-NA study, p. 22. Historical comparison is not a 2026 inflation reading. Scenario formula: $\text{cost} = \$40\text{M} \times (1 + \text{assumed annual rate})^{\text{years}}$. It does not quantify product savings.

04 / REQUIREMENTS AND VERSIONS

A source is useful only if its status is clear.

Record the issued version, applicability and next review trigger—not just a saved link.

01 Buy American / BABA [3]

For AIP-funded work, verify the current FAA preference, conformance record and any product- or project-specific waiver. Do not carry a prior waiver forward without checking the live FAA list and the grant conditions.

02 DBE / ACDBE transition [4]

Until the relevant UCP completes reevaluation, recipients may not set DBE contract goals or count participation toward DBE goals. Check the live UCP status for the jurisdiction. Nondiscrimination clauses and prompt-payment duties continue.

03 AIP Handbook: draft is not issued guidance [5]

Draft Order 5100.38E has not been issued. Its comment period closed August 31, 2026. The active handbook remains 5100.38D, Change 1, until FAA publishes a final replacement; later legislation and policy also matter.

Give every authority a status

Draft

Monitor proposals. Do not treat them as effective requirements.

Effective

Record version, date and why it applies to this project.

Project-specific

Verify the grant, waiver, clause and delegated authority for this commitment.

[3–5] Official FAA and DOT sources linked on p. 15. Status checked September 2, 2026; recheck live sources before solicitation, award and distribution. This is not a complete legal review.

05 / EVIDENCE

The record is not administrative overhead.

Airport guidance and Federal audits show why documented reasoning and supporting evidence matter.

ESTABLISHED AIRPORT PRACTICE [6]

ACRP already calls for a Project Delivery Decision Report.

Report 21 recommends documenting the project description, goals, methods considered, selected delivery method and supporting rationale. This guide applies the same continuity principle beyond one delivery-method choice.

DOT OIG / AIP PAYMENTS [7]

12.5%

OIG estimated that about \$751M of \$6B in FY2015–2016 AIP payments did not comply with FAA eInvoicing supporting-documentation requirements. The audit also identified about \$1M in questioned costs.

DOT OIG / STATE BLOCK GRANTS [8]

\$87.9M

OIG estimated FAA did not evaluate projects awarded this amount and reported that FAA had not required Block Grant States to document project-selection decisions.

WHAT THESE SOURCES DO—AND DO NOT—SHOW

They support disciplined, reviewable records. They do not show that every airport has the same weakness, that documentation alone prevents delay, or that any one vendor or tool is the solution.

[6–8] ACRP Report 21 and DOT OIG reports FI2018101 (2018) and AV2021017 (2021). Audit findings concern the reviewed programs and periods; figures are OIG estimates, not current sector-wide failure rates.

06 / DELIVERY MODEL

Keep disciplines connected. Keep authority explicit.

A useful project record follows the decision across organizational boundaries.

01 / DEFINE Planning Need, scope, alternatives and dependencies.	02 / QUALIFY Funding Eligibility, conditions and financial capacity.	03 / VALIDATE Approvals Environmental, technical and delegated authority.	04 / DELIVER Procurement Applicable method, competition and contract.	05 / RETAIN Closeout Acceptance, evidence and continuing duties.
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Conceptual disciplines, not a statutory sequence. Work can run in parallel or return to an earlier decision when facts change. Requirements vary by project, funding and jurisdiction.

At every handoff, transfer four things

- 01 The decision and its status**
What has been decided, by whom, and what remains provisional?
- 02 The basis**
Which project facts and current sources support the conclusion?
- 03 The unresolved condition**
What assumption, approval or missing evidence could change the route?
- 04 The next accountable owner**
Who must do what next, and before which commitment?

KEEP THE ROUTES DISTINCT

Construction, professional services, equipment and IT do not necessarily use the same buying method. A capital-plan entry does not establish funding or reimbursement eligibility.

TarmacSync practical framework. [13] FAA identifies FY2026 as the fifth and final AIG installment; this report does not infer availability, eligibility or award for any project. Airport and authorized reviewers retain accountability.

07 / WORKED EXAMPLE

One project. Several connected decisions.

Hypothetical case: AIP-supported taxiway rehabilitation. No grant share, threshold or approval outcome is assumed.

DECISION AREA	WHAT THE TEAM NEEDS TO ESTABLISH	RECORD TO RETAIN
Planning and scope	What condition is being addressed? Is the proposed scope aligned with the current plan?	Scope basis, alternatives and source dates.
Environment / approvals	Which reviews and approvals apply, and what is their status?	FAA coordination, applicable authority and open conditions.
Funding	What work is eligible and what grant conditions attach?	Funding basis and restrictions; unresolved eligibility questions.
Procurement	Which method, competition and clauses apply to this contract?	Current policy, grant conditions, rationale and authorized review.
Construction phasing	How will work interfaces and operating constraints be managed?	Phasing assumptions, responsible reviews and decision triggers.
Closeout	What will demonstrate acceptance and support reimbursement or audit?	Evidence checklist, owners and continuing obligations.

EQUIPMENT VARIATION / \$180,000 RUNWAY SWEEPER

A proposed purchase using operating funds starts with different questions. A cooperative contract may be a candidate route, but the team must verify local authority, scope fit, approvals and all funding conditions before relying on it.

The amount is a scenario estimate—not an applicable procurement threshold.

Composite illustrations, not actual airport projects or legal determinations. The example identifies questions; it does not preselect a compliant procurement route.

08 / THE REUSABLE RECORD

Make the next review start from evidence.

A compact working record for the taxiway example. Unresolved items stay visible.

ILLUSTRATIVE PROJECT NOTE / STATUS: OPEN FOR VALIDATION

FIELD	WORKING ENTRY
Facts established	Taxiway rehabilitation is the proposed scope; AIP support is part of the scenario. Actual eligibility and award conditions are not established here.
Sources and versions	Link the current capital-plan entry, scope basis, environmental status, funding documents and procurement policy when obtained. Record version and date.
Assumptions	Any assumed funding timing, approval status or operating window is marked unconfirmed until validated.
Decision rationale	Not yet determined. Record the selected method and why it applies only after the responsible professionals review the facts.
Open questions	Applicable approvals? Eligible work? Procurement method and clause set? Phasing constraints? Evidence needed before commitment?
Owner / next action	Project lead coordinates the source check with grants, procurement and engineering. Assign named owners and a due date before the next commitment.
Change history	Date each update. Retain the previous conclusion and explain why new facts or authority changed it.

RECORD THE RATIONALE AND THE APPLICABLE THRESHOLD

Where 2 CFR 200.318(i) applies, retain the method and contract-type rationale, selection or rejection, and price basis. Current Federal ceilings are \$15,000 for micro-purchases and \$350,000 for simplified acquisitions; an eligible recipient may annually self-certify a micro-purchase threshold up to \$50,000 with supporting documentation. State, local or airport policy may be lower. [9]

Template, not a product screenshot or authorization to proceed. [9] Live eCFR sections 200.318 and 200.320, current through August 31, 2026; FAR thresholds are incorporated by reference. Confirm project-specific applicability and any lower policy limit.

09 / HANDOVER

Make the handover a usable record.

Preserve the airport's decision history in the systems and relationships it already trusts.

01 Finance / ERP

Link the commitment or payment to the applicable authority and decision record.

02 Project management

Keep the condition behind a task alongside its owner, due date and status.

03 Document repository

Retain controlled sources and connect each to the conclusion it supports.

04 Consultants and counsel

Capture project-specific advice, its scope and any conditions on reuse.

05 Email and working files

Move material decisions out of isolated threads into the maintained project record.

The successor test

Ask a colleague unfamiliar with the decision to explain it from the record. Note what they still need to ask.

This is a working practice, not a claim of software integration. Existing systems may already support these functions.

THE HANDOVER RECORD

Facts

What is established?
What is still assumed?



Sources

Which authority applies?
Which version was used?



Decision

What was selected?
Why does it fit?



Next owner

Who acts next?
What remains open?

The project continues.
Its reasoning should travel with it.

10 / TEAM DIAGNOSTIC

How well does the reasoning survive?

Use one recent decision to discuss these four descriptions. No scoring or maturity certification is implied.

DESCRIPTION	WHAT THE RECORD LOOKS LIKE	DISCUSSION PROMPT
Reconstructed	Reasoning depends on individual memory and scattered messages.	What must the next reviewer rebuild?
Documented	Files are available, but the basis of the decision is not connected.	Which conclusion still needs explanation?
Connected	Facts, sources and rationale are linked for review.	Can a new colleague follow the decision?
Maintained	Decision history is updated and prior research is revalidated.	What triggers a new source check?

Four questions for the project team

- 01 Method**
 Can we explain the last procurement method from the record?
- 02 Continuity**
 Would the reasoning survive a change in project lead?
- 03 Readiness**
 Are missing facts visible before solicitation or review?
- 04 Reuse**
 Do we check currency before applying research to a new project?

CHOOSE ONE IMPROVEMENT

Project / missing evidence / owner / review date

TarmacSync facilitated discussion tool. It is not a validated scoring model, an audit, or a measure of sector-wide performance.

11 / PRACTICAL FIELD GUIDE

Eleven habits. No new system required.

Bring this page to the next project review. Choose one habit, one owner and one live project.

CALENDAR DISCIPLINE

- 01 Work backward.** Align the schedule with current funding, procurement and approval milestones.
- 02 Maintain a ready list.** Keep a shortlist of capital items with known dependencies and open questions.

RECORD DISCIPLINE

- 03 Write the rationale.** Capture method, contract type, selection and price basis at the decision.
- 04 Retain the competition.** Preserve the solicitation, responses, evaluation and required justifications.
- 05 Name the assumption.** Separate unconfirmed information from established project facts.

CLAUSE DISCIPLINE

- 06 Maintain a clause matrix.** Key applicability to funding, contract type, value and other triggering facts.
- 07 Recheck at award.** Confirm that changed facts have not changed the required clause set.

CONTINUITY HABITS

- 08 Keep one project brief.** Facts, assumptions, open questions, next action and owner.
- 09 Ask the exit question.** Before handover, record why the chosen method and route were used.
- 10 Reuse carefully.** Start with the prior record; verify that its sources and facts still apply.
- 11 Build closeout during delivery.** Keep the narrative and evidence current while the work is fresh.

A source, a reason and a next owner.
Start with the decision in front of you.

Practical guidance, not a complete compliance checklist. Apply current grant conditions, local policy and project-specific requirements.

12 / TARMACSYNC

Know the path. Show the reasoning. Preserve the expertise.

Airport procurement intelligence, evaluated against the project decisions your team actually needs to make.

TarmacSync's public product description centers on a candidate procurement path informed by project facts, funding and policy context, with source visibility and an exportable record. These are first-party descriptions, not independently tested capabilities. [10]

Questions to ask before adopting any decision-support tool

QUESTION	WHAT A SOUND ANSWER SHOULD SHOW
Evidence	Does the tool distinguish established facts, assumptions and missing information?
Authority	Can airport professionals open the source, confirm its version and assess why it applies?
Project fit	Does the workflow reflect the project scope, funding conditions and airport policy context?
Governance	Are required reviews, approvals, accountable owners and unresolved conditions visible?
Continuity	Can another airport professional inspect, export and continue the decision record?

Confirm current capability

Separate functions available today from configuration, manual support and planned development.

Native ERP/financial-system integration is not offered in the current public description. This report makes no claim of active beta deployment, named airport partners or measured performance gains.

Keep authority with the airport

A suggested route is not a grant determination, FAA approval, legal opinion or procurement authorization.

[10] TarmacSync public website, reviewed through the cited public description. Product operation and availability were not independently verified. Evaluate any tool against current policy, funding conditions and authorized review.

13 / PRACTICAL CLOSE

Apply the guide to one live project.

Turn the report into one useful action before the next commitment.

CHOOSE ONE UPCOMING DECISION AND RECORD**01****Facts and sources**

The established facts and current source versions.

02**Open condition**

The unresolved condition that could change the path.

03**Accountable owner**

The airport professional responsible for the next action.

04**Review date**

The date before the next commitment is made.

A useful project record makes the current reasoning visible, reviewable, and easier to carry forward when the work changes hands.

Report boundary

This guide provides practical decision-record guidance. It is not a compliance determination, grant approval, legal opinion, procurement authorization or substitute for current project-specific review.

For opted-in readers

The weekly Airport Infrastructure series continues by email for readers who chose to receive it. No response or additional information is requested here.

Apply current grant conditions, local policy, project-specific requirements and authorized professional review before commitment.

14 / SOURCES

Evidence, versions and scope.

Numbering follows first appearance. Verify regulatory status before use.

01 ACI-NA · 2025–2029 Infrastructure Needs Study

2025 edition, pp. 9 and 22. Supports \$173.9B and historical cost increases of 38.3% and 31.7%. The cited cost passage specifies “since 2014,” not a confirmed 2024 endpoint.

[Open source ↗](#)

02 FAA · National Plan of Integrated Airport Systems

2025–2029 narrative; published September 30, 2024, update listed July 22, 2026. Table 4 reports 12 named categories totaling \$67.599B. The FAA current-NPIAS page still lists this edition.

[Open source ↗](#)

03 FAA · Buy American / BABA

FAA's live AIP page states the preference, certification and waiver routes and links current conformance and waiver records. Page updated August 27, 2026; verify the project-specific record at commitment.

[Open source ↗](#)

04 DOT · DBE / ACDBE interim final rule

Effective October 3, 2025. Updated December 1, 2025 FAQs address UCP reevaluation, suspended goals/counting, nondiscrimination clauses and prompt payment. Check the live jurisdiction status.

[Open source ↗](#) · [UCP status ↗](#)

05 FAA · AIP Handbook status

Draft 5100.38E comment period closed August 31, 2026. The active order record remains 5100.38D, Change 1 until final replacement.

[Open source ↗](#) · [Active order ↗](#)

06 ACRP Report 21 · Project delivery decisions

The National Academies guidebook uses a Project Delivery Decision Report to document the selection process and outcome. This guide complements that established airport-industry resource.

[Open source ↗](#)

07 DOT OIG · eInvoicing and AIP grant payments

FI2018101, September 12, 2018. Supports the 12.5% / \$751M statistical estimate and approximately \$1M in questioned costs for the reviewed periods and sample.

[Open source ↗](#)

15 / SOURCES AND PRODUCTION

A transparent record of what this guide uses.

Direct links for guidance, product context and licensed photography.

08 DOT OIG · AIP State Block Grant Program

AV2021017, February 10, 2021. Supports the \$87.9M estimate and the finding that FAA had not required Block Grant States to document project-selection decisions.

[Open source ↗](#)

09 eCFR · Federal award procurement

Live 2 CFR 200.318(i) requires procurement-history records. Section 200.320 ties informal methods to FAR thresholds and permits documented annual micro-purchase self-certification up to \$50,000.

[Open source ↗](#) · [Methods and thresholds ↗](#)

10 TarmacSync · Public product description

First-party positioning and stated integration limits, reviewed through the cited public description. Not independent verification of product operation, deployment or service fulfillment.

[Open source ↗](#)

11 Photography · Unsplash License

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[Open source ↗](#)

12 Cover · CHUTTERSNAAP

Airport-interior photograph on p. 1; layout crop and tonal overlay applied. No airport location or endorsement is asserted.

[Open source ↗](#)

13 FAA · Airport Infrastructure Grants

FAA identifies FY2026 as the fifth and final \$2.89B AIG installment. This report does not treat an allocation as available money, establish project eligibility or make an IJJA-cliff forecast.

[Open source ↗](#)

Current as of September 2, 2026

Method. Claims were checked against the linked primary source or authoritative industry publication; exact NPIAS Table 4 values were used before rounding. Dynamic regulatory claims were checked against live FAA, DOT and eCFR pages. The separate source ledger records claim, source, status and editorial treatment.

Limits. Audit findings concern the reviewed programs and periods and are not current sector-wide failure rates. Scenarios are illustrations, not forecasts. Recheck live funding, waiver, UCP, handbook and procurement sources before commitment. This guide is not legal advice, grant approval or procurement authorization.